

purity of the Book when the world around him on. India of 2008 was one such place for him.



blood spilled, its sanctities desecrated... God has blessed a group of vanguard Muslims, the forefront of Islam, to destroy America. May God bless them and allot them a supreme place in heaven..."

Those words by Islam's Che-in-the-cave hardly hide the enormity of hate or the imaginary history of suffering. They celebrate the cult of martyrdom and promise paradise to the killer. Replace America with another country and the words won't lose its resonance. Al Qaeda may not be the operational base of terror any longer and Osama may be withering away somewhere in the Pakistan-Afghanistan border, though the idea continues to

kill and the dateline of death keeps changing and the killer never stops updating the technology to make every strike as spectacular as 9/11. The terrorist has become the fastest traveller in the so-called flat world. He has already caused the first two wars of this century. The war in Iraq has cost one of the world's most ruthless dictators his country as well as his life, and made the warrior-in-chief the least popular president of America in recent history. It has also set the stage for the first African-American occupant of the White House. If Iraq is the just war that has gone wrong, the war in Afghanistan is about to get added priority under the new dispensation in Washington. The war on terror unites nations and divides the mind. When the terrorist kills and, invariably gets killed, he achieves more than martyrdom; he becomes a force that can change the course of national histories. He becomes the arbiter of our everyday life.

India should know. The horror of 9/11 may have introduced America to the reality of a brand new Evil Empire. India's experience with Islamist terrorism is older than 9/11. We have been living through it with our unmatched sense of sangfroid. Then, the tragedy of Kashmir has never been spectacular. Even the attack on the Indian Parliament

in the afterglow of 9/11 has failed to make us one of the most vulnerable victims in the eyes of the rest. We were alone in our suffering and we excelled in our stoicism—in our pathological passivity. The terrorist could not have chosen an easier battlefield, for in the wake of every attack on India, we saw the grotesquerie of politics feasting on the dead. Lives were getting cheaper here, dispensable and disposable; it was as if we were swarming marketplaces and railway compartments to make jihad a story told in the blackened blood of India. And the face that reflects in the blood that India shed in

